The Sevenfold Praise of the Glorious Guru Vanaratna

Śrīguruvanaratnastotrasaptaka · Toh 1177 · Derge Tengyur
དཔལ་ལྡན་བླ་མ་ནགས་ཀྱི་རིན་ཆེན་གྱི་བསྟོད་པ་བདུན་པ

The Sevenfold Praise of the Glorious Guru Vanaratna, known in Sanskrit as Śrī Guru Vanaratna Stotra Saptaka and in Tibetan as Palden Lama Nakkyi Rinchen gyi Töpa Dünpa, is a short verse eulogy of the Indian monk and scholar Vanaratna, who was active in Nepal and Tibet in the fifteenth century. Its stanzas extol him as a strict keeper of the monastic vows of the Vinaya, a master of the Great Vehicle who knows the nondual nature of phenomena, a lion before rival debaters and a refuge for all beings, and they credit him with turning the king of Nepal toward the way of the Buddha. According to its colophon, it was composed by a lay devotee from Magadha whose name means the Sun, and it was translated into Tibetan by the Tsetang translator Shönu Pal at the command of the Chennga, the Dharma King. It is Toh 1177 in the Tengyur, where it stands in the section of praises (stotra), and it is unusual there in honoring a human master of comparatively late date rather than a buddha or a deity.

In Sanskrit: śrī guru vanaratna stotra sabtakaṃ
In Tibetan: The Sevenfold Praise of the Glorious Guru Vanaratna.

I pay homage at the feet of the glorious guru Vanaratna.

He who set the king of the land of Nepal
to strive constantly to follow the way of the Sugata (the Buddha),
who became a treasury for the learned and illumines the depths
of the host of consummate qualities, a king among monks,

far renowned, whose fame, beyond compare,
is his victory banner, canopy and silken streamers, whose mind is profound and vast,
whose person too is the sole refuge of sentient beings,
a treasury of tenets through true realization of the Great Vehicle,

is the one called Vanaratna, of supreme mind among keepers of vows.
This elder here knows the true nature of nondual phenomena;
through the vows of the Vinaya he strives earnestly in perfect restraint;
to opponents, those lordly elephants, he is the lion, king of beasts.

Homage to the supreme one among the kings of great keepers of vows,
in whom full certainty in the supreme way is born,
the one supreme deliverer of beings from their sufferings!
Supreme indeed is the great elder Vanaratna.

Free of passion, he awakens all sentient beings without exception;
in his lotus hands he holds the weapon of the bow;
his beautiful body has become the ornament of the earth;
the great elder Vanaratna is surpassingly beautiful.

From stains such as joylessness and the elephant of joy,
from stain, he has known what it is to be stainless and free;
he is master of the twofold target, existence and nonexistence;
the great elder Vanaratna has become a refuge.

To me, who bow for the nectar of primal dispassion, he is gracious;
gracious, through hundreds of branches of sure discipline
he attends to the hosts of sentient beings in their hundreds, fully ripened:
such is the great elder Vanaratna.

He leaves the mouths of Māra's hosts and the rest without savor;
the lotus of his mouth crushes what is filled with foes;
he washes the opponents, lords of mountains, whose sense bases tremble;
he who washes them is the great elder Vanaratna.

The Sevenfold Praise of the Glorious Guru Vanaratna is complete. It was composed by the excellent layman called Sun, who hailed from the land of Magadha. This was translated by the Tsetang translator Shönu Pal at the command, accompanied by golden flowers, of the Chennga, the Dharma King.

Translator's Notes

- From the fourth stanza on, the verses imitate a Sanskrit chain figure (yamaka), in which a line takes up a word from the end of the line before, and the compressed Tibetan leaves several images uncertain: "the weapon of the bow" (mtshon gyi gzhu); "the ornament of the earth," which reads 'dzin pa'i mthil (literally "the surface of the holder") as a rendering of Sanskrit dharātala; "who bow for the nectar" (btud pa); and "attends to" (rtsi mdzad). The word dga' bral, literally "free of joy," is read as the stain of joylessness (arati) beside "the elephant of joy" in the sixth stanza and as dispassion in the seventh; an allusion to the tantric joy of cessation (viramānanda) is also possible. The written gnas brten and ri dgas are read as gnas brtan, "elder," and ri dags, "beast." The author's name, Nyimapa, means "the Sun one"; its Sanskrit form (Sūrya, Ravi, Āditya and others are possible) cannot be identified with confidence, so it is translated. The patron, spyan mnga' chos kyi rgyal po, is taken as a title, "the Chennga, the Dharma King"; Chökyi Gyalpo could also be a personal name. Several glossary words occur here in other senses: yul "land," bka' lung "command," dbang "lord," las "from," mtha' within grub mtha' "tenets" and mthar thug "consummate," bdud rtsi "nectar," and bdag "me."

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.